

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Voice in Your Head

You have a voice in your head.

Not metaphorically. Literally. There is a voice that runs commentary on what you do, all day, every day, in your own internal monologue — and you have had it as long as you have had language, and it is one of the most consistent companions of your life, and most of you have never been told this voice has a name.

The name is the Internal Critic.

Yours might sound like your mother. Yours might sound like a teacher. Yours might sound like a coach who told you, in fourth grade, that you would never be a real athlete. Yours might sound like a kid who teased you so consistently in second grade that you internalized his voice and now use it on yourself in seventh grade — and he is not even in your life anymore, but his voice is, and it is delivering the commentary now, and that — when you actually think about it — is one of the strangest and saddest facts about being a person.

Mostly the voice goes unexamined. It just is, the way the weather just is. You make a mistake, the voice talks. You speak up in class and it comes out wrong, the voice talks. You catch yourself in the mirror, the voice talks. You scroll through your phone, the voice talks. You walk into the cafeteria, the voice — somewhere underneath the noise — is talking.

Mr. Patel, in the first week of November, gave the cohort a chair and a journal and seven minutes of silence and asked the question that most of them had never had asked of them before.

What does the voice in your head say, exactly? Write down the actual words.

The cohort wrote. Some fast. Some slow. The cohort had, in pieces over the years, been given language for this voice before — Ms. Calloway had named the Inner Critic for them in fourth grade, in a small way, and Priya had named hers in third grade in a bathroom stall — but Mr. Patel was asking them to do something specific. Not acknowledge the voice. Transcribe the voice. Write the actual words.

This is what they wrote. We will not show you everybody's. We will show you Priya's, because Priya, of all the cohort, has had the longest practice with the Inner Critic.

Priya wrote, in her notebook in Room 36, on a Tuesday in November:

The Critic says: you are stupid. You are slower than the kids in this honors class. You are pretending to belong here. You are going to be found out by Christmas. You should drop down to regular before the school figures out you cannot keep up.

The Critic says: you are weird. The lunch you brought today smells different. The kids at the science table noticed last week. They did not say anything but they noticed. They are going to start saying things.

The Critic says: you are exhausting. The cohort has been listening to you talk about the Critic since third grade. They are tired of you. They are not going to say so, because the cohort is the cohort, but they are tired. They want a Priya who is not always in some version of the same drama with herself.

The Critic says: you are not as good as Hannah. Hannah is naturally what you have to work to seem like. Hannah is the version of you that the world is going to want. You are going to spend your whole life pretending to be Hannah, badly.

She read what she had written.

She read it three times.

She looked up.

The cohort, around her, had also written. Marcus had written less. Theo had written about a paragraph. Amara had written half a page. None of them, in this exercise, was performing or curating — they were all just transcribing, in the privacy of their notebooks, the voice they had been hearing in their heads for years.

Mr. Patel said, *now read what you wrote. Slowly. Once.*

The cohort read.

Mr. Patel said, *now I want you to imagine, for one second, that a friend — your best friend, the one who knows you better than almost anyone — was sitting next to you, and you turned to them, and you said that to them. Out loud. In that voice. With that intensity.*

He paused.

You would not. You would not, in a million years, talk to your best friend the way you talk to yourself.

He paused again.

That gap is one of the most important gaps in this entire room. We are going to spend the rest of this unit in that gap. Because if you would not speak to a friend that way — would not, in fact, even let somebody else speak to your friend that way without intervening — then why, exactly, is it acceptable to speak to yourself that way?

The room was silent.

He said, the honest answer is that you did not choose the voice. It was installed. It came from somewhere — a person, a moment, a system, a culture — and you did not have a choice in the installation. But you are old enough now to ask whether you want to keep it running at the current volume. That is a real question. That is one of the questions of November.

He let the silence sit.

Then he said:

Tomorrow we will learn what the three tactics of the Critic are. Today, we just sat with the voice. Today was the noticing. That is enough for today.

The bell rang. The cohort walked out.

Priya, in the hallway, walked next to Marcus.

She said, Marcus.

He said, Pri.

Did you transcribe yours.

Yes.

Was it bad?

Pri. It was about what I figured it would be. The Critic in my head has been the Critic in my head for a long time. The transcription did not say anything new.

But seeing it in writing.

Yes. Seeing it in writing is different.

I know.

Pri. The cohort knows. The cohort has known since third grade. The Critic in your head is one of the longest-running members of our extended cast. You are not exhausting.

Marcus.

I know. The Critic says you are exhausting. The Critic is wrong. I am — I am the cohort. I am authorized to tell you what the Critic is wrong about.

She laughed.

He said, *come on. We are going to be late.*
They walked to fourth period.